

M4 Carbine: US-made, this 5.56 x 45 mm calibre gun is a shorter version of the M16A2 and is used by Indian special forces

● 500m ● 2012 ● 1,500

AK-103: The 7.62x39mm AK-103, a variant of the AK-47, has superior penetration, stopping power. Used by the Navy's MARCOS commandos

● 350m ● Early 2000s ● 5,000



SIG Sauer 716: This 7.62 x 51 mm assault rifle has a piston-driven operating system that softens the gun's recoil and increases accuracy. It is replacing the INSAS in many army units

● 600 m ● 2019 ● 72,000



T91 assault rifle: A Taiwan-made rifle used by the army special forces and IAF's Garud. It has greater reliability in maritime conditions

● 400 m ● 2000 ● 1,000

FN F2000: Used by the Special Protection Group, its unique ejection system provides for fully ambidextrous operations

● 500 m
● 2005
● 600

SG 551: Swiss-made, gas operated 5.56 mm assault rifle designed for close combat and urban missions. Used by elite NSG

● 400 m
● 2000s
● 600



"ARMY HEADQUARTERS WAS NEVER CLEAR ON WHAT TYPE OF WEAPON IT WAS LOOKING FOR. MANUFACTURERS WILL COME TO YOU WHEN YOU DECIDE WHAT YOU WANT"

LT GEN. D.S. HOODA (RETD), *Former Commander, Northern Command*

tions, where we need an assured kill."

Faced with a malfunctioning INSAS, army headquarters was unsure of what rifle to procure. In 2011, the army floated a global tender for an assault rifle with interchangeable barrels. The programme was junked after four years as it failed to pass field trials. Top-of-the-line assault rifles such as Beretta's ARX-160 (Italy), Colt Combat Rifle (the US) and CA 805 BREN (the Czech Republic) failed to rise up to the unrealistic army GSQR. The experiment had to fail, for no army in the world has a two-calibre rifle as its basic weapon. "If a soldier needs to carry two barrels and two types of ammunition...the total battle load would have increased by at least 10 kg, reducing mobility," says a senior army official.

After scrapping the idea of interchangeable barrels, the Indian Army again had a rethink about its guiding principles vis-a-vis assault rifles—the debate over a 7.62 mm rifle with assured killing power or a 5.56 mm rifle that sought to incapacitate was reopened. Eventually, in 2016, all top army commanders decided to import the more powerful 7.62 x 51 mm rifle—the longer, heavier calibre bullet causing more grievous, potentially fatal wounds—for their infantry battalions and counter-insurgency units with "higher kill probability and stopping power". The recent decision to buy 7.62 x 51 mm Sig Sauer assault rifles reflects this decision.

However, two more disappointments lay in store for the army. In 2016, it rejected the 5.56 mm Excalibur assault rifle—a gas-operated, automatic rifle with a foldable butt that was an upgraded version of INSAS—developed by DRDO—over quality standards. In 2017, the army refused to use a 7.62 x 51mm prototype assault rifle developed by the Rifle Factory Ishapore. The rifles apparently backfired. "The military never trusted Indian manufacturers, as soldiers have to bear the brunt of a faulty weapon," says a colonel.

Eventually, India decided to fall back on its largest arms supplier, Russia.

AK-203 & SIG SAUER

India and Russia signed an inter-governmental agreement for AK-203 assault rifles—a fifth-generation (the previous generations being AK-47, AKM, AK-74 and the AK-100 series) assault rifle of the famous Kalashnikov family with 7.62 x 39 mm calibre—in February 2019. Subsequently, in 2021, during Russian president Vladimir Putin's visit to India and the inaugural India-Russia 2+2 dialogue, a deal for manufacturing AK-203 rifles in India was signed. The Indo-Russia Rifles Private Limited (IR-